Start off with a good-quality, home-made stock for this fragrant, light, refreshing soup, then serve it piled high with fresh herbs and chiles.

vietnamese noodle soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 25–30 MINS PLUS SOAKING TIME **COOK** 25 MINS PLUS SITTING TIME **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

1¼ quarts (1¼ liters) chicken stock, preferably homemade
6 slices ginger (no need to peel)
½ tsp coriander seeds
4 star anise
2 stalks lemongrass, sliced
2 skinless, boneless chicken breasts
3½oz (100g) rice noodles
2 bok choy, very thinly sliced
Asian fish sauce, to taste
3½oz (100g) bean sprouts
small bunch cilantro, about ¾oz (20g), coarsely chopped
small handful mint leaves, finely shredded
2 scallions, thinly sliced
1 large fresh red chile, seeded (unless you like it hot) and thinly sliced
lime wedges

1 Pour the stock into a large saucepan, and add the ginger, coriander seeds, star anise, and lemongrass. Simmer gently for 10 minutes. Lower the chicken breasts into the stock and continue simmering for 15 minutes. Remove from the heat and let sit for 5 minutes. Meanwhile, break the noodles (so they are easier to eat) into a large heatproof bowl and cover with boiling water. Let soak for the time suggested on the package.

2 Remove the chicken from the stock with a slotted spoon and transfer it to a cutting board. Slice the chicken into very thin bite-sized strips. Strain and discard the flavorings from the stock and return the stock to the pan. Drop in the bok choy (off the heat) and let it wilt in the warmth of the stock. Return the chicken to the stock along with a dash of fish sauce.

3 Drain the noodles and divide between 4 big bowls. Lay the bean sprouts on top. To serve, ladle the chicken and hot stock over the noodles and top each bowl with a generous scattering of the cilantro, mint, scallions, and chile; add another splash of fish sauce. Offer lime wedges for squeezing over the top.